

Personal Statement

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Program: Computer Science and Engineering M.S.E.

The defining cadence of my undergraduate years was set not in a laboratory, but in a pool. As a varsity swimmer and City-Level Gold Medalist, I committed to over eight hours of high-intensity training weekly. This physical discipline taught me that “oxygen debt” is temporary, but the grit required to push through it is permanent. I applied this same resilience to a significant academic barrier: pivoting from Mechanical Engineering (ME) to Computer Science (CS).

Navigating this cross-disciplinary transition was isolating. Entering the world of algorithms from a background of dynamics and thermodynamics, I initially lacked the foundational syntax of my CS peers and felt like an outsider in a “gatekept” community. However, overcoming this steep learning curve gave me a unique vantage point. I realized that my value wasn’t just in mastering code, but in bridging the gap between the physical constraints of hardware and the abstract logic of software. This struggle motivated my decision to pursue graduate studies; I realized that to build truly robust robotic systems, I needed to formally master the language of CS to complement my intuition for ME.

This experience shaped my core identity: I am not just an engineer; I am a “Technical Bridge.” This philosophy transformed my approach to leadership as the Chapter Lead of the Google Developer Student Club (GDSC). I noticed that non-CS majors often felt intimidated by the rigid culture of technical academia. To counter this, I acted as a “Translator.” I recall mentoring a Literature major paralyzed by API logic; rather than simply correcting her syntax, I framed the code as a narrative structure with a distinct grammar. Her breakthrough reinforced my belief that diverse metaphors make technical concepts more robust. By orchestrating workshops for over 40 diverse students, I fostered an ecosystem where electrical engineers could fearlessly debate architecture with software theorists, proving that cross-disciplinary friction is fuel for innovation.

My commitment to human-centric engineering extends beyond campus walls. Initiating a meal distribution program for the homeless in Taipei was an exercise in “human-centered logistics.” I applied my optimization background to streamline procurement, yet quickly realized that efficiency metrics fail when they ignore human dignity. Managing these logistics grounded my high-level research ambitions in gritty reality, reminding me that a system is only as robust as its ability to serve the most vulnerable.

I seek to join the University of Michigan not only to advance my technical research but to contribute to a community that values this breadth of perspective. The MSE in CSE at UMich is the ideal environment to refine my role as a technical bridge-builder. I plan to organize interdisciplinary roundtables—specifically connecting students from the Robotics Institute with CSE theorists—to foster a collaborative environment where admitting “I don’t know” is the first step toward discovery. By sharing my lived experience of navigating academic barriers, I hope to ensure that the UMich engineering community remains not just intellectually elite, but profoundly inclusive.